

Giraffes Can Count Carrots, Scientists Say

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Giraffes are the **tallest** land animals on Earth. Now scientists say giraffes can also do simple math!

Researchers from the University of Barcelona in Spain tested four giraffes at the Barcelona Zoo. The giraffes love carrots, so the scientists used carrots in the test. The giraffes saw carrots in two yellow boxes. Then they watched the scientists add more carrots to one of the boxes. To get it right, a giraffe had to pick the box with the most carrots.

Two giraffes, Nuru and Njano, picked the right box every time. The other two used **shortcuts**, such as picking the box the scientist's hand touched last.

The test got harder when carrots were taken away or moved more than once. Then all the giraffes had trouble. Still, the study shows giraffes can keep track of small numbers.

The study was **published** on June 26, 2026. Scientists think math skills might help wild giraffes find the best food.

Word Treasure

Researchers -- People who study something carefully to learn new facts.

shortcuts -- Quicker ways of doing something that skip some steps.

published -- Shared with the public, often in a magazine or online.

tallest -- Higher than all the others.

Background you need

Scientists test animals with games and treats to learn how they think.

Being able to tell which pile has more food can help animals survive in the wild.

Break it down

WHO: Researchers from the University of Barcelona and four zoo giraffes

WHAT: The giraffes showed they can keep track of small numbers of carrots

WHERE: The Barcelona Zoo in Spain

WHY: To learn whether giraffes can do simple math, which might help them find food

Why it matters

Just like kids comparing snacks, animals may count to choose the best food.

Test what you remember

1. What did the scientists use in the test?

- ☐ (A) Leaves
- ☐ (B) Bananas
- ☐ (C) Apples
- ☐ (D) Carrots

2. How many giraffes were tested?

- ☐ (A) Ten
- ☐ (B) One
- ☐ (C) Four
- ☐ (D) Two

3. Where do these giraffes live?

- ☐ (A) On a farm in Ohio
- ☐ (B) In a desert
- ☐ (C) At the Barcelona Zoo
- ☐ (D) In a forest in Canada

4. Which giraffes picked the right box every time?

- ☐ (A) Only the youngest one
- ☐ (B) Nuru and Njano
- ☐ (C) All four
- ☐ (D) None of them

5. When did the test get harder for the giraffes?

- ☐ (A) At night
- ☐ (B) When the boxes were big
- ☐ (C) When it rained
- ☐ (D) When carrots were taken away or moved more than once

6. What might math skills help wild giraffes do?

- ☐ (A) Swim
- ☐ (B) Sleep longer
- ☐ (C) Find the best food
- ☐ (D) Run faster

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: C 4: B 5: D 6: C

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):